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Launch Readiness

An honest US launch go/no-go: gate-by-gate scorecard and a 90-day plan that closes gates and ships zero new features.

ARGUS FINANCIAL PARTNERS · CONFIDENTIAL — FOUNDER · JUNE 24, 2026

Strategic guidance only — not legal, financial, tax, or investment advice.
Securities, money-transmission, and corporate-formation decisions must be reviewed by licensed counsel and a CPA before you act. Sections flagged “ see counsel” are where this matters most.

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Launch Readiness — honest scorecard + 90-day gate-closing plan

A candid go/no-go on launching Argus in the US: where each gate actually stands, who owns it, and the shortest dependency-ordered path to a real launch. **No new features** — this is about closing gates.

How to read this. Companion to `LAUNCH.md` (the gate definitions B1–B8), `CORPORATE-STRUCTURE.md` (the Corp A/B/C ramp), and `GO-LIVE-PLAN.md` (entity + ownership + GTM). Status: ● not started · ● in progress · ● done. Tags: **DO NOW**, **DEFER → Corp B/C**, **see counsel**.

Honest opinion + readiness map — not legal advice. Entity, MSB, securities, and money-transmitter decisions must go through the fintech attorney + CPA named in `CORPORATE-STRUCTURE.md` / `GO-LIVE-PLAN.md`.

1 1. The verdict

Not ready to fully launch — and the gap is not features, it's gates. The codebase is feature-rich and architecturally strong (append-only ledger, non-custodial keys, DID/VC + agent rails, a real fraud engine, disciplined prod-fatal config). But "launch a US money business" is gated on **legal · licensing · partners · verification**, and almost none of that is done. **More prototype features do not close a single gate.**

Two doors:

- **Door 1 — narrow Phase-A launch** (non-custodial *software*, **no customer funds**, money rails OFF, testnet, RWA demo-only). The only door open in **weeks-to-months**, and it's mostly *non-engineering* work (counsel, vendor contracts, app verification). **Still not ready** — see §2.
 - **Door 2 — the full neobank** (deposits, cards, FX, Argus Pay, real trading/RWA). **Corp B/C: multi-quarter-to-multi-year, capital-intensive**, gated on a partner bank + FinCEN MSB + real vendors + licensing + production custody + SOC 2 + an ops org that doesn't exist yet. See §3.
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2. Phase-A scorecard (Door 1 — the only near-term path)

These are the `LAUNCH.md` B1–B8 gates plus the Phase-A compliance items, scored honestly.

Gate	Status	Owner	Evidence today	Effort
Entity formed (WY LLC) + EIN + registered agent	●	Founder	<code>B6</code> checklist all unchecked	1–2 wks
IP assignment (repo/marks → LLC)	●	Founder/Counsel	Not executed; #1 diligence item (<code>GO-LIVE-PLAN.md</code>)	days ☹
Operating agreement	●	Founder/Counsel	Not adopted	days ☹
AML/BSA policy + named compliance officer	●	Founder/Counsel	No written policy	2–4 wks ☹
Real OFAC/sanctions screening	●	Eng + Vendor	<code>SANCTIONS_PROVIDER=simulated</code> (stub)	2–4 wks
Real KYC/IDV (if onboarding real users)	●	Eng + Vendor	<code>IDV_PROVIDER=simulated</code> (stub)	3–6 wks
ToS / Privacy / E-Sign / "not advice" disclaimers	●	Counsel	Not published	2–3 wks ☹
Compliance-safe messaging (no "bank"/"deposits"/"FDIC")	●	Product/Legal	Rebrand done; copy review pending (<code>LAUNCH.md</code> §1)	days
B1 — iOS wallet verified	●	Eng	Source never compiled (no Xcode)	1–3 wks
B2 — Frontend + Playwright UI smoke	●	Eng	Portal built; <code>wallet.spec.ts</code> green TBD	1–2 wks
B3 — <code>e2e-validator</code> <code>full</code> green	●	Eng	Deterministic floor green; full hybrid TBD	days–1 wk
B4 — Securities counsel sign-off (if real RWA)	●	Counsel	<code>docs/legal/B4</code> is a scaffold	3–6 wks ☹
B5 — Collectibles legal memo	●	Counsel	<code>docs/legal/B5</code> is a scaffold	2–4 wks ☹
B6 — Entity + Phase-A compliance pack	●	Founder/Counsel	scaffold, all unchecked	rolls up the above ☹

Gate	Status	Owner	Evidence today	Effort
B7 — Hedera posture (testnet-labeled OR mainnet KMS/HSM)	●	Eng/Sec	Testnet OK to launch <i>labeled</i> ; mainnet needs KMS/HSM+multisig	testnet: now
B8 — Trail of Bits wallet audit	●	Sec	"ENGAGEMENT PLANNED — not scheduled"	schedule now; 4– 8 wks to report

Phase-A reality: ~everything red is **paperwork, counsel, vendor contracts, and app verification** — not code. The engineering that remains (B1/B2/B3) is small next to the legal/compliance lift.

3 3. The Corp-B wall (Door 2 — every money rail is gated)

`backend/src/config.ts` makes **14 capabilities prod-fatal**. Each is a prototype on a simulated provider; flipping it on in production is blocked until its real prerequisite exists. **Do not flip any of these for launch.**

Prod-fatal switch	What it enables	Blocking prerequisite	Phase
BANK_RAILS_ENABLED	deposits / ACH / wire	BaaS partner bank + FinCEN MSB + KYC/AML vendor	Corp B ⚙️
CARDS_ENABLED	debit cards	card processor + BIN-sponsor bank + PCI scope	Corp B ⚙️
ARGUS_PAY_ENABLED	stablecoin merchant rail	money-transmission licensing / partner	Corp B/C ⚙️
FX_ENABLED / FX_SETTLEMENT_ENABLED	currency conversion	licensed FX rate provider + MT posture	Corp B/C ⚙️
BILLPAY_ENABLED	bill pay	partner bank + biller network	Corp B ⚙️
TRADING_ENABLED	brokerage	broker-dealer/clearing partner	Corp C ⚙️
EQUITIES_ENABLED	tokenized equities	issuer + transfer agent + ATS + securities counsel	Corp B/C ⚙️
COLLECTIBLES_ESCROW_ENABLED	in-app collectible escrow	MSB / marketplace-intermediary counsel	Corp B ⚙️
TEEN_ENABLED (+ credit/custodial)	teen suite	BaaS/card issuer + COPPA + custodial broker	Corp B/C ⚙️
DATA_WAREHOUSE_ENABLED	analytics sink	real warehouse (not blocking launch)	Stage 1

Also missing for a real money product (not seams — operational reality): customer support/ops console, dispute/chargeback ops, statements + tax docs (1099-INT/B/DIV), production notifications, real-time fiat rails (FedNow/RTP — today "instant" is a label), multi-chain reconciliation (Hedera-only today), fraud at scale (in-process, not Kafka/Flink), SOC 2, insurance (E&O/D&O/cyber), and a status page + incident-response runbook.

4. The 90-day gate-closing plan (ships ZERO new features)

Dependency-ordered. The goal of 90 days is **Door 1 ready**, *not* Door 2. Costs are planning estimates.

Sprint 1 (Days 1–30) — exist + freeze + engage

- **Freeze feature scope.** No new seams. Pick the wedge: **web-first, non-custodial, no customer funds, collectibles viewing + agent experience, money rails OFF, RWA demo-only.** (Owner: Founder. Exit: written one-paragraph scope, all money switches confirmed off in the prod env template.)
- **Form the entity + EIN + registered agent + operating agreement; execute the IP assignment.** *(Founder
 - Counsel. Exit: **B6** entity rows checked; signed IP assignment. ~\$2–4k $\approx$)*
- **Engage fintech/securities counsel + a startup CPA** (scoped hours). (Founder. Exit: engagement letters signed. ~\$5–15k $\approx$)
- **Schedule the Trail of Bits audit (B8).** (Eng+Sec. Exit: SOW signed, dates booked.)
- **Close B3 + start B2:** get **e2e-validator full** green and the Playwright wallet smoke running. (Eng. Exit: green run artifacts.)

Sprint 2 (Days 31–60) — compliant + verifiable

- **Write the AML/BSA policy; name the compliance officer; wire a REAL OFAC/sanctions vendor** (swap **SANCTIONS_PROVIDER** off simulated). (Founder/Counsel + Eng. Exit: policy doc + a live SDN screen on onboarding. $\approx$)
- **Wire a real KYC/IDV vendor** if onboarding real users (else keep waitlist + manual). (Eng. Exit: one real identity verified end-to-end, or a documented decision to defer with no real onboarding.)
- **Decide iOS vs. web-only for v1** and close it: either pass **verify-ios-wallet.sh** + device smoke (B1), or **launch web-only** and shelve the app. (Eng. Exit: B1 green OR a written web-only decision + B2 green.)
- **Draft ToS / Privacy / E-Sign / disclaimers** with counsel. (Counsel. Exit: published-ready drafts. $\approx$)

Sprint 3 (Days 61–90) — launch posture + the Corp-B decision

- **Securities posture (B4/B5):** counsel sign-off, or keep all RWA explicitly demo-labeled and ship nothing real. (Counsel. Exit: signed memo OR enforced demo-only. $\approx$)

- **Publish ToS/Privacy/disclaimers; finalize compliance-safe messaging review.**
(Counsel/Product.)
- **Lock the Phase-A prod config:** Hedera testnet-labeled (B7), every money switch off, password auth off — and run `LAUNCH.md` \$6 go/no-go with all four sign-offs.
(Eng/Founder. Exit: a real GO on the \$6 checklist.)
- **Begin the Corp-B conversation (do NOT build):** shortlist a **BaaS partner bank** + start **FinCEN MSB** prep so the *first* money rail has a home after Door 1 is live. (Founder/Counsel. Exit: partner shortlist + MSB checklist — not an integration. $\mathbb{P}$)

Outcome at day 90: a defensible **Phase-A launch** (or invite-only beta) of non-custodial software, or a clear-eyed decision to stay in private testing — with the Corp-B path scoped but not yet built.

5 5. The one-line answer

You're **not** missing features — you have more than enough. You're missing an **entity, counsel, real compliance vendors, app verification, and a partner/licensing path**. Stop building; start closing gates.

Companion documents: `LAUNCH.md` (gate definitions + \$6 sign-off), `CORPORATE-STRUCTURE.md` (Corp A/B/C ramp), `GO-LIVE-PLAN.md` (entity/ownership/GTM), `docs/legal/` (B4–B6 scaffolds), `docs/security/TRAIL-OF-BITS-AUDIT.md` (B8).